The 1980s saw no real activity and the number stayed at 33,650 km in 1991. The real upsurge came in the 1990s when more than 24,000 km of other roads were upgraded to national highways. India had 57,737 km of national highways at the commencement of the new millennium in 2001. The number increased at a steady pace to 70,934 km in 2011.

There has been a rush to declare more roads as national highways in the second decade of the twenty-first century, more pronouncedly after the NDA government took over in 2014. From a length of 79,116 km at the end of 2013, national highways grew to 91,287 km in 2014. As per the annual report of the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways (MoRTH), the length of national highways stood at 1,32,500 km at the end of 2020. Essentially, the number grew from just about 80,000 km at the end of the UPA's second term to 1,32,500 at the end of 2020, an increase of 52,500 km in less than seven years—an annual increase of over 7500 km per year!

What is the right length of national highways in India? What should be the criterion for declaring a highway a national highway? What explains these spurts and fits and starts in growth? The current phase of national highways expansion is quite instructive in this respect.

The NDA government, more specifically MoRTH, decided sometime in 2014 that as many state highways as possible should be converted into national highways. The criterion for declaring a highway a national highway was relaxed. A new class of 'in-principle' declaration of national highways commenced in 2014. As a result of this policy, as per the note issued by PIB in July 2019, as many as 71,898 km of state highways were approved as 'in-principle' national highways since April 2014, 'subject to the outcome of their Detailed Project Reports (DPRs)'. Of these, highways of 19,170 km length were declared national highways until July 2019.

National highways should be viewed as a national grid of large interstate carriageways connecting major ports, production centres and human habitation, requiring movement of goods and passenger vehicles of